

the surface of the water until she closed in on her target. Then she would use her rudders to submerge.

On the night of February 17, 1864, lookouts on the screw sloop USS *Housatonic* reported a slight wake approaching. Their ship already had a head of steam up and was just getting underway to avoid the assailant, when the barbed head of a 130-lb (59-kg) spar torpedo lodged in her timbers. The torpedo exploded, and in a few minutes the *Housatonic* settled to the bottom in shallow water. Only five of her crew had been killed; most of the rest climbed into the rigging to await rescue. From there they spied lantern signals from a nearby vessel, but these vanished. The *Hunley*, the world's first submarine to sink an enemy ship, had foundered for some unknown reason and gone down with all hands.

TORPEDO From the Latin word *torpere*, meaning to stupefy, the term once applied to all military and naval mines, perhaps because of their sudden shocks.